tra] got more Indian-ised after the [*Bahubali*] films." But even while *Brahmastra* is epic in its canvas, Mukerji clarifies that there is a key aspect that sets his Ranbir Kapoor- and Alia Bhatt-starrer apart. "There is also the filmmaker in me writing about young, modern relationships," adds Mukerji. "It gave me confidence and reaffirmed the faith of everybody who was involved in the project."

Brahmastra had been brewing in Mukerji's mind even as he was making *YJHD*. As a child, he says he grew up having a connection with Indian gods and goddesses. By his 30s, Mukerji had what he refers to as a "feeling", a "spiritual call" that told him that his fantasy trilogy needs to emerge from "the primal and powerful" stories he has read and heard. He headed to the hills—retreats in the Himalayas—to start shaping the story. *Brahmastra*, he says, is "what Shiva means to me. It's a homage to the spirit of Lord Shiva. It's modern spirituality at its core." Over two years, a pictorial script of *Brahmastra* was developed, detailing its visual landscape.

With *Brahmastra*, Mukerji has created his "own universe of cinema", one he calls the "Astraverse". He has also set up a film company, Starlight. "It could mean that I probably give up my lifetime to only making these films, my own version of Marvel," he says. That said, the future of his fantasy action series does depend on the success of the first film. In Shiva, though, Mukerji believes. ■

- Suhani Singh

ENTERTAINMENT

Full Stream Ahead

We only ever knew Imtiaz Ali for his love stories, but OTT platforms are showing the filmmaker in a new light

Up until February 14, 2020, Imtiaz Ali was best known as a chronicler of modern love. There was something simultaneously contemporary and old-fashioned about his romances, be it *Jab We Met* (2007), *Love Aaj Kal* (2009) or *Tamasha* (2015). Then came *She* (2020–), a Netflix series about a police constable who goes undercover as a prostitute. Produced by Ali's banner, Window Seat Films, the dark, sensuous thriller was a far cry from anything he had done on the big screen. Streaming, he feels, has "liberated" him by allowing him to give up the romantic tag and revisit the many stories he had put on the backburner.

For once, "duration" was not a hurdle. Ali learned to embrace a new role–that of a showrunner–and "emphasise his creative vision in absentia" by trusting other writers and directors. It was they who infused new energy and perspective into his stories. Ali, though, still had his plate full. He has conducted workshops with actors like Aaditi Pohankar (*She*) and has also been involved in post-production.

It's how both his shows, *She* and the latest SonyLIV series, *Dr Arora*, got made. The idea for *Dr Arora*–a sex doctor battling inhibitions in small-town India–had been with Ali for a while. "While taking the train from Jamshedpur to Delhi, I'd always be fascinated by the many hoardings for sex doctors, their services and products," says Ali. "There's a certain discomfort that comes with it and it was interesting for me to see how people in small towns deal with it."

The writer-director has seen OTT come of age in the past two years. "Early on, when OTT platforms came to us, they asked us for ideas that had worked in the West," citing the success of shows like *Narcos*. The deluge of crime dramas and thrillers emerged from that need, he notes. "But now a fatigue has set in and in the past few months, they [platforms] are asking me to suggest love stories that could lend themselves to the long format."

Busy as he has been writing, Ali is also currently focused on returning to the director's chair. His next will be his first biopic–on the popular and controversial Punjabi musician Amar Singh Chamkila. Actor-singer Diljit Dosanjh has been roped in to play the lead. Speaking about Chamkila, Ali talks about the many layers of the artist's life, layers that might enable him to delve and explore themes such as "censorship". More accustomed now to sharing writing duties, Ali has roped in two writers, including one from Punjab "to help with the local flavour". Also, given Ali's stellar record on delivering memorable soundtracks, Chamkila and Ali promise to be a match made in heaven.

- Suhani Singh

IMTIAZ ALI will soon be directing his first biopic, which will be on the popular and controversial Punjabi musician, Amar Singh Chamkila



MANDAR DEODHAR